

THE FIRST IMPRESSION

Before it was a relic, it was news.



PHILADELPHIA / JULY 4-5, 1776

A printer's night. A document on its way to the world.

Contemporary reconstruction

THE DOCUMENT HAD TO LEAVE THE ROOM.

Public words. Public life.

The Declaration did not begin behind glass. It went to a working print shop. From there, copies traveled to assemblies, committees and commanders.

This is a story about different hands and different roles: the printer's eye, the working draft, the first impression, the public reading, and the argument in the newspaper.

Read the words. Keep the source.

AN ORIGIN STORY FROM THOMAS BROADSIDE CO.

01 / BENJAMIN FRANKLIN

He knew what a page could do.



THE CRAFT, BEFORE THE FOUNDING

Long before the Declaration, Franklin made his living in print. Almanacs, pamphlets, newspapers: useful words, carried into ordinary life.

He later helped revise the Declaration's draft.

Contemporary reconstruction / Sources and links on page 12

02 / THOMAS JEFFERSON

The words were worked on.



PHILADELPHIA / JUNE-JULY 1776

Jefferson was the principal draftsman. His colleagues and Congress revised the text before its adoption on July 4. The original Rough draught is full of the marks of that work.

The surviving manuscript lets us follow the revisions.

Contemporary reconstruction / Sources and links on page 12

03 / JOHN DUNLAP

A declaration needed a printer.



PHILADELPHIA / JULY 4-5, 1776

After Congress approved the text, it went to John Dunlap's Philadelphia shop. Through the night of July 4 and into July 5, the Declaration became a printed broadside: a sheet carrying type on one side.

The printed words could now leave the room.

Contemporary reconstruction / Sources and links on page 12

04 / GEORGE WASHINGTON

The sheet became a voice.



NEW YORK / JULY 9, 1776

John Hancock sent a printed copy to Washington on July 6. On July 9, Washington had the Declaration read aloud to the troops assembled in New York.

A fragment of Washington's printed copy survives.

Contemporary reconstruction / Sources and links on page 12

05 / ALEXANDER HAMILTON

The argument kept moving.



NEW YORK / 1787-1788

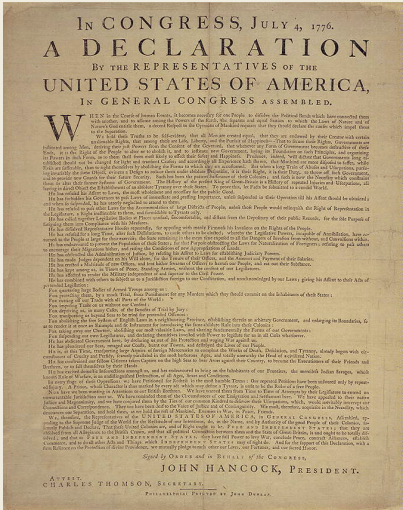
The founding did not end in July 1776. During the debate over the Constitution, Hamilton, James Madison and John Jay wrote as Publius, arguing for ratification through print.

A later debate. A different document. Print again.

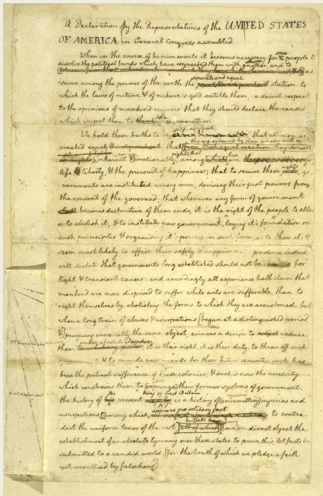
Contemporary reconstruction / Sources and links on page 12

THE SURVIVING RECORD

From draft to public sheet.



DUNLAP / FIRST PRINTING



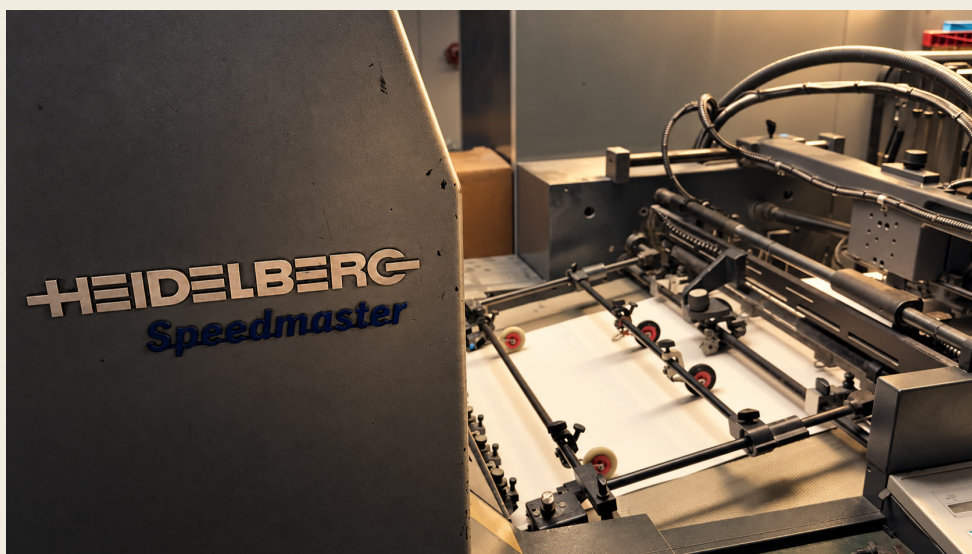
JEFFERSON / ROUGH DRAFT

At left: the first printing, with the printed names of Hancock and Thomson. At right: Jefferson's working draft. The familiar signed parchment came later.

Reference reproductions from the Library of Congress. Follow the linked source record for the originals and their context.

06 / THE WORK CONTINUES

Different century. Same conviction.



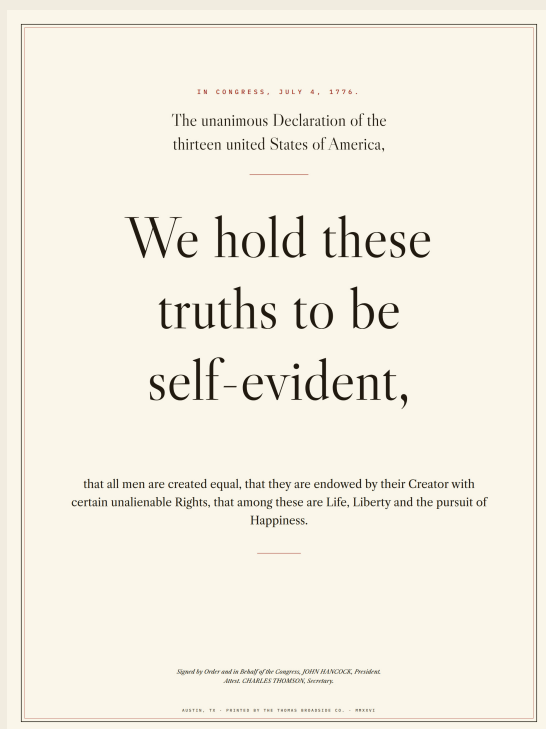
THOMAS GRAPHICS / AUSTIN, TEXAS

A working press. A sheet you can hold. Words with a source you can follow. At Thomas Broadside Co., the heritage becomes something to live with, read again, and pass on.

Art-directed shop photograph

THE COLLECTION / THE DECLARATION

A place for the words.

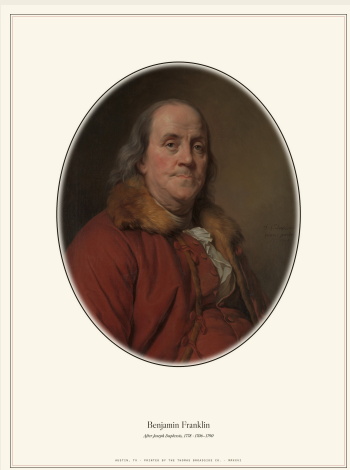


Our Declaration is a contemporary composition of its celebrated passage, set in Caslon. A new design inspired by the broadside tradition, printed in Austin.

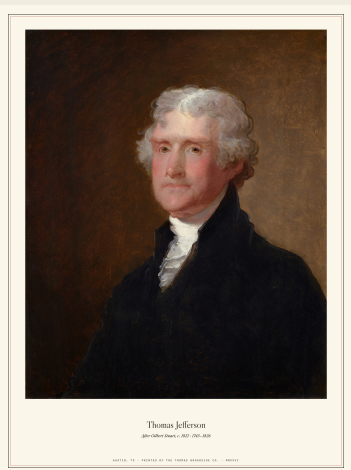
Contemporary print; not an original artifact or Dunlap facsimile.

THE COLLECTION / THE FOUNDERS

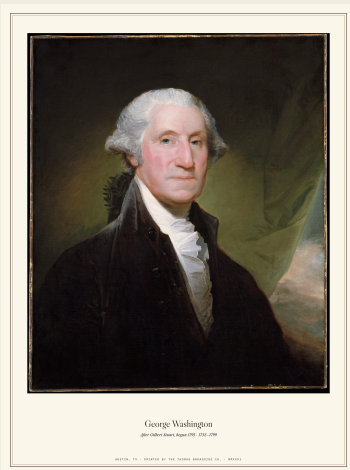
Bring the story
into the room.



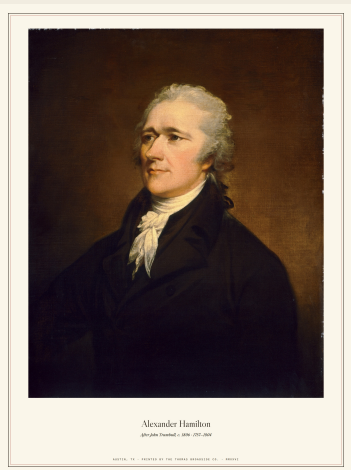
FRANKLIN



JEFFERSON



WASHINGTON



HAMILTON

THE RECORD BEHIND THE STORY

Keep the source.

01 / The first printing, July 4-5, 1776

Library of Congress / National Archives

02 / Jefferson's original Rough draught

Library of Congress, Jefferson Papers

03 / Franklin, printer and writer

Library of Congress

04 / Washington's copy of the Declaration

Library of Congress, George Washington Papers

05 / The Federalist in historic newspapers

Library of Congress

06 / Printing the Declaration of Independence

Library of Congress, Rare Book and Special Collections

07 / Declaring Independence: drafting the documents

Library of Congress

Period scenes are contemporary reconstructions, with imagined rooms, gestures and incidental people. Narration and score are modern. The Austin footage records the actual shop.

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